What do you want to be ready to explain?

Read the job description alongside what you've learned from the recruiter or earlier interviews. Check the company's website and current public information. What would you be responsible for, and what would you need to deliver?

Make a short prep list

For the work that matters most, write:

- What the role needs
- An example I could discuss
- What I still need to know

Your examples can come from work, study, volunteering or other responsibilities. Start with the résumé you sent, then look for relevant experience it leaves out.

Let an earlier answer improve your next question

If the recruiter says a manager currently handles the work you'd take over, prepare an example of taking responsibility. Ask the manager: "Which decisions would I make independently?"

Use each interviewer's connection to the work to choose questions for them. Their job title doesn't tell you what they'll ask. Ask the recruiter about the interview format so you can prepare for any exercise.

One experience can give you several answers.

Write enough to explain what was happening, what you did, why you chose that approach and what happened afterward. Include other people’s contributions.

A fictional answer about helping a colleague

“New cashiers were unsure when a return needed a supervisor and would call me over while I was helping customers. I wrote a checklist from our existing policy, including exceptions so they’d know when to get approval. My supervisor checked it before I shared it. On a later shift, a new colleague used it to handle a straightforward return without calling me over.”

What else could you explain with it?

“How did you use your judgment?” → Why the checklist kept the exceptions and supervisor review.

“Tell me about improving a process.” → The repeated interruptions, the checklist and the result you observed.

Do this with your own examples

Beside each example, write the questions it could answer and the detail you’d use for each. Keep other examples ready for questions this one doesn’t answer.

Make the answer easier to say and remember.

Pick a question and answer aloud. Have a friend or AI ask a follow-up, or try one yourself: “Why that approach?” “What other option did you consider?” “How did you know it helped?”

Use what you notice

Could someone listening tell what you did and why? Add the detail they’d need, then try again. Practice a different question about the same experience; use another example if it fits better. Rehearse your introduction, why you want the role and any confirmed exercise too.

Keep the full answers and make these short notes

My opening: experience to lead with and why this role interests me.

My examples: give each one a name, then note the questions it could answer, the result and the details to remember.

My questions: what I need to learn and who could help answer.

For example: “Returns checklist”
Use for: helping a colleague or using judgment.
Remember: policy, exceptions, supervisor review.
Result: a new colleague handled a return independently.

Review these before the interview; use them during it if notes are allowed. After each round, add what you learned and what you want to ask next.

More questions to practice: UC Davis Career Center

If you want AI to help

Provide what you have and tell it where you want to start. You can return to research or missing details later.

Copy this prompt

Help me prepare for an interview. Work one stage at a time and wait for me before continuing.

1. Use or ask for the job description, résumé I sent, experience notes, interview details and notes from earlier rounds.

2. Research the company and role. Link current sources; mark unknowns. If you can't browse, ask for sources. Use interviewers' professional roles to shape my questions, without guessing what they'll ask me.

3. Suggest questions to practice and examples from my experience that could answer them. Ask what I did, why and what happened before drafting; don't invent details. Show different ways to use an example, and where another one would fit better.

4. Help me draft full answers, my introduction and why I want the role. Prepare questions that build on what I know and help me decide whether the job fits what I want.

5. Ask one practice question and wait. Ask a follow-up and wait. Tell me what was clear, what was missing and what to change. Let me retry. Include any confirmed exercise or interview format.

When I ask, make short notes: my opening, why this role, questions I might be asked with example names and key details, and questions for each interviewer. Keep the full answers separately.